http://www.wizards.com/default.asp?x=sideboard/feature/20030703a Go JUN JUL OCT
10 captures 29 Jul 2003 2002 29 2003 2004 About this capture

Giant-Sized Week in Review: June 18-July 1

Jeff Cunningham

Due to technical errors, last week's Review was not posted. It has been included in this week's.

Welcome to Week in Review.

Let's see what's in the news today.

Nationals: Canada

Ninety-eight competitors showed up to this year's Canadian Nationals, which was held at the site of last year's Grand Prix-Montreal. The tournament would be the second to use a new format: three rounds of Standard, followed by six rounds of draft, and then three more rounds of Standard (the first tournament to use this format was South Africa Nationals). The atmosphere was one of excitement, as if it was not a **Magic** tournament, but a giant birthday party. "Where was the cake?" we wondered, child-like.

The supposed pros dropped like flies: "Pant-Flyin" Ryan Fuller, "Pistol" Peter Radonjic, "Cool" Aeo Paquette, Mark "the Real Deal" Zadjner and Jurgen Hahn had a combined grand total of 0 points by the end of round 3. This is not to say, though, that the cream did not rise; by the end of the first day, the top of the standings had many of the best names in Canadian **Magic**: Gabriel Tsang (the original German Juggernaut), Guilliaume Daoust (a founding member of Team 2020), Gary Wise (of *Sideboard* column Wise Words), "Lucky" Louis Boileau (a member of last year's team in Sydney), and Elijah Pollock (Junior Pro Tour sensation) were all present.

Notably absent from the top of the standings was golden goddess Jeff Cunningham. The Canadian people were deeply saddened by this.

Also falling by the wayside were Dave Rood, Jon Stern, Jeff Fung, Jason Howden, and Steve Cassel.

After a shocking second day of competition that saw both Gary Wise and Gab Tsang lose four straight rounds in row, a strong Top 8 was announced: Elijah Pollock, Steven Wolfman (whose crude comments in Gary Wise's last article provoked much controversy), Josh Rider, Guilliaume Daoust, and Pro Tour-Yokohama Top 8er Rich Hoaen. The Top 8 contained a Wake deck, a Psychatog deck, a black-green deck, three blue-green madness decks, and two monoblack control decks.

As Rider's black-green is designed to mangle control decks, the finals were a blowout, with Braymore (MBC,) falling in three straight.

The 2003 Canadian Nationals Team is Josh Rider, Nathan Braymore, and Rich Hoaen, definitely a talented squad. These guys are young guns, so watch out all you olde Europeane teams... the new world has arrived and they like rock and roll. This team definitely has a solid shot of taking the prize at Worlds... if their mommies let them go! Ha ha, nice one ffej... Er... In any case, good luck gentlemen, for mother Canada rests on your shoulders.

Here is Josh Rider's winning deck:

Josh Rider
2003 Canadian Nationals

Main Deck		Sideboard
3 City of Brass	4 Cabal Therapy	2 Braids, Cabal Minion
10 Forest	4 Living Wish	1 City of Brass
9 Swamp	3 Oversold Cemetery	2 Engineered Plague
	4 Smother	1 Faceless Butcher
22 land		1 Genesis
	15 other spells	1 Mindslicer
4 Birds of Paradise		1 Nantuko Vigilante
2 Braids, Cabal Minion		1 Phantom Centaur
1 Caller of the Claw		1 Ravenous Baloth
2 Faceless Butcher		2 Ray of Revelation
3 Llanowar Elves		1 Stronghold Assassin
3 Phantom Centaur		1 Withered Wretch
2 Ravenous Baloth		
3 Stronghold Assassin		15 sideboard cards
3 Wirewood Herald		
23 creatures		

You can check out Gary Wise's Canadia Nationals preview here.

You can check out the coverage here.

Nationals: Japan

This year's Japan Nationals brought out 167 players to the Mipro Exhibition Center in Tokyo. Only seven players that were qualified did not attend - and three of those seven were last year's National Team! Come on guys, we know you had a rough time, but keep your chin up.

Japan, alongside Canada, was the second tournament to use the 3-6-3 format change.

At the end of the first day, Masahiro Kuroda (Team Masters winner,) topped the standings, with Itaru Ishida and teammate Katsuhiro Mori close behind.

After the second day, though, almost none of the known Japanese pros had made Top 8, except for the "silver collector" Osamu Fujita (2nd GP-Hiroshima, GP-Taipei, APAC Championships.) The Top 8 contained two red-green decks, one Psychatog deck, one monoblack control deck, one blue-green madness deck splashing for Zombie Infestation, one Zevatog deck, one Ponza deck, and one very interesting white-green-red beast deck. The Japanese are renowned for deck innovation and in the current Standard format, which is being called stale by many, it's nice to see some creative deckbuilding tweaks.

Also, I'd like to note that Japan Nationals has some wacky prize payout. $20,000 for first, and only $500 for eighth? Sorry Makihito Mihara, that's a rough beat.

Koutarou Ootsuka (u-g-b) defeated Osamu Fujita (MBC) 3-1 in the finals thanks, in large part, to sideboard Composts.

The 2003 Japanese National Team is Koutarou Ootsuka, Osamu Fujita and Tooru Maegawa. Let's hope these guys make Oosio proud.

Here is Ootsuka's winning deck:

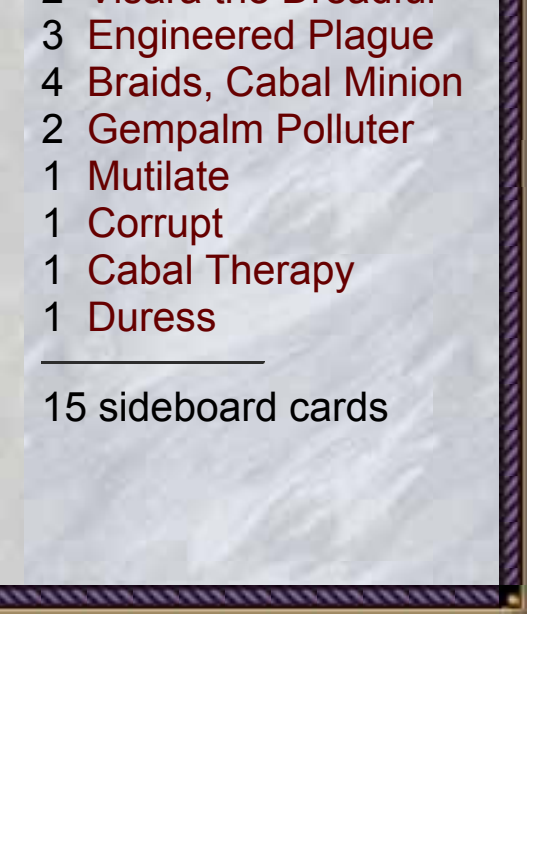
Koutarou Ootsuka
2003 Japanese Nationals

Main Deck		Sideboard
4 Polluted Delta	4 Circular Logic	3 Compost
3 City of Brass	3 Smother	3 Engineered Plague
2 Underground River	2 Quiet Speculation	2 Turbulent Dreams
9 Forest	2 Roar of the Wurm	2 Duress
4 Island	2 Zombie Infestation	2 Cabal Therapy
1 Swamp	2 Deep Analysis	1 Ray of Revelation
	1 Ray of Revelation	1 Coffin Purge
23 land	1 Upheaval	1 Smother
4 Wild Mongrel	17 other spells	15 sideboard cards
4 Merfolk Looter		
4 Arrogant Wurm		
3 Phantom Centaur		
3 Basking Rootwalla		
2 Wonder		
20 creatures		

Event coverage can be found here.

Nationals: Argentina

A couple years ago, Argentina was almost non-existent on the pro **Magic** map. Now it is a fountain of talent, having spawned names like Ostrovich, Barbero, and Ostrovich Maher Jr.



The tournament used the now very much outdated six rounds of Rochester Draft followed by six rounds of Standard format.

In a heart-breaking upset, Diego Ostrovich missed the Top 8, finishing 16th place.

The Top 8 contained four blue-green Madness decks, a Psychatog deck, two zombie decks, and a Wake deck.

The 2003 Argentinean National Team is Jose Barbero, Ariel Nagy, and Matias Gabrenja. I don't see Diego, so that means this team's chances exist somewhere between poor and very poor. Kidding, kidding... Jose Barbero's been putting up great finishes since Pro Tour-Yokohama where he ran the swiss, and Matias Gabrenja is a fellow Bandana teammate. Expect this team to have a strong showing... as long as Barbero can control himself and avoid unsportsmanlike conduct warnings!

Here is Barbero's winning deck:

Jose Barbero

Main Deck		Sideboard
2 Unholy Grotto	3 Cabal Therapy	2 Visara the Dreadful
23 Swamp	3 Smother	3 Engineered Plague
	3 Mutilate	4 Braids, Cabal Minion
25 land	2 Corrupt	2 Gempalm Polluter
	3 Duress	1 Mutilate
4 Nantuko Shade		1 Corrupt
4 Rotlung Reanimator	14 other spells	1 Cabal Therapy
4 Graveborn Muse		1 Duress
4 Withered Wretch		
2 Cabal Archon		15 sideboard cards
3 Stronghold Assassin		
21 creatures		

Very detailed event coverage can be found here.

Nationals: Uruguay

Uruguay Nationals took place this past Sunday, with 29 of the 45 qualified players turning up. The tournament was three rounds of Rochester Draft followed by three rounds of Standard. Only three u-g madness decks were present. Three. That's only twelve measly copies of Careful Study in the entire Nationals.

The Top 8 contained an Astral Slide deck, three red-green decks, a blue-green deck, a white-green beast deck, a blue-green Opposition deck, a Reanimator deck, and a monoblack control deck splashing blue.

Jorge Sierra (red-green) defeated the fifteen year old Nicolas Magniano (Astral Slide) in the finals to take the precious Uruguayan crown.

The word on the street is that Magniano is the next Cole Swannack... could the rumors be true? Time will tell if Nicolas has got "it", that special quality that made Cole Cole.

The 2003 Uruguayan National Team is Jorge Sierra, Nicolas Magniano, and Guzman Villanova. Guzman Villanova has Worlds experience, so hopefully he can take his teammates under his wing, and teach them a few things about **Magic** (and life!).

Here is Jorge Sierra's winning deck:

Jorge Sierra
2003 Uruguayan Nationals

Main Deck		Sideboard
4 Wooded Foothills	3 Violent Eruption	1 Grim Lavamancer
4 Karplusan Forest	4 Volcanic Hammer	2 Caller of the Claw
6 Forest	4 Firebolt	2 Flash of Defiance
7 Mountain	4 Call of the Herd	3 Compost
1 Barbarian Ring		3 Nantuko Vigilante
	15 other spells	4 Ensnaring Bridge
22 land	**(61 cards)**	
		15 sideboard cards
1 Jeska, Warrior Adept		
3 Grim Lavamancer		
3 Phantom Centaur		
3 Elephant Guide		
2 Blistering Firecat		
4 Llanowar Elves		
4 Wild Mongrel		
4 Basking Rootwalla		
24 creatures		

Coverage can be found here.

Nationals: Venezuela

Venezuela Nationals took place the weekend before last, with fifty-two stout Venezuelans in attendance. There were three rounds of Rochester Draft followed by four rounds of Standard.

Daniele Daversa (MBC,) took down Edgar Morillo (w-g beasts) in the finals.

The 2003 Venezuelan National team is Daniele Daversa, Edgar Morillo, and Daniele Fior. For the record, I think these guys are just super.

Coverage can be found here.

Nationals: United States

US Nationals took place in swingin' San Diego this past weekend, with 199 players competing. The tournament would be the last to use Standard without Scourge, and followed the 3-6-3 format.

The action started on Thursday, as all five of the Grinders filled up to maximum 256 player capacity! Competition was at an all-time high, with pro players Brett Shears and Dave Williams failing to make the cut despite "a whole lotta hopin'."

Once the tournament was underway, it was apparent that the metagame had visibly shifted from that of a few months ago.

Notable players to qualify in the Grinders were Your Move Games' Little Darwin, Paul Reitzl, and SoCal local Chris Demaci, both of whom would later choke in the last round of Nationals to miss Top 8.

Also getting in at the eleventh hour: Brock Parker (who would dub the Nationals event his "last chance, last dance",) old-schooler Frank Gilson, upstarts Bryn Kenney and Justin Bonomo, and possibly related to off-and-on pro Tim McKenna, Michael McKenna.

Once the tournament was underway, it was apparent that the metagame had visibly shifted from that of a few months ago. U-g, for example, was only the fifth most popular deck! R-g took the top spot, and was followed closely, in order, by Wake, Psychatog and zombies. Also apparent after the first few rounds: Gary Talim was 0-3 and officially off the gravy train. Initial reports regarding the reasons behind the poor performance cite "manascrew again". Rest in peace Gary.

After the first day, three players sat at 6-0: ***Magic** Online* terror Mike "Pegleg" McGee, Brian Kibler, and James Cross. Close behind were Dave Humphreys, Phil Freneau, Craig Krempals, Gerard Fabiano and Matt Rubin, among others.

Brian Kibler would continue his run on the second day, getting to 9-0 (6-0 in Limited,) before conceding to friends Neil Reeves and Jon Finkel. McGee and Cross would not be as fortunate, though McGee would finish in the money.

After the tenth round, the Top 8 was shaping up to be extremely impressive, with Kibler, Reeves, Finkel, and Turian already assured spots. Two rounds later, after some alternately tense Feature Matches, the Top 8 was rounded out by veteran drafter Gabe Walls, Pro Tour-Venice Semifinalist Jordan Berkowitz, PT-Houston Champion Justin Gary, and GP-Boston Quarterfinalist Josh Wagener. Narrowly missing the cut on tiebreaks were "Tight" Thomas Guevin (who was especially pained after a vicious last round Feature Match) and Craig Krempals.

The Top 8 contained 3 red-green decks, 1 Upheaval/Zombie Infestation deck, 1 monoblack control deck, 2 zombie decks, and a red-green-white Astral Slide deck.

Despite arguably the best Top 8 in U.S. Nationals history, cruel Quarterfinals matchups would eliminate all but one of the more experienced players, Justin Gary, who would fall to Wagener's 4 Composts in the semifinals. Walls defeated old friend Berkowitz in the other semifinals matchup, a battle reminiscent of that Star Trek where Picard has to fight Tasha Yar, or something like that.

The finals were a lopsided affair, but not for the expected favorite. Gab Walls' Astral Slide deck fell to Wagener's r-g deck in three, bafflingly, considering Walls had beaten two r-g decks to make it to the Finals!

The 2003 U.S. National Team is Josh Wagener, Gab Walls, and Justin Gary.

Though many were disappointed with this team considering the caliber of some of the players eliminated in the Quarterfinals, I think it's the favorite for Worlds. Take it from me, these guys can play.

Here is Josh Wagener's winning deck:

Josh Wagener
2003 U.S. Nationals

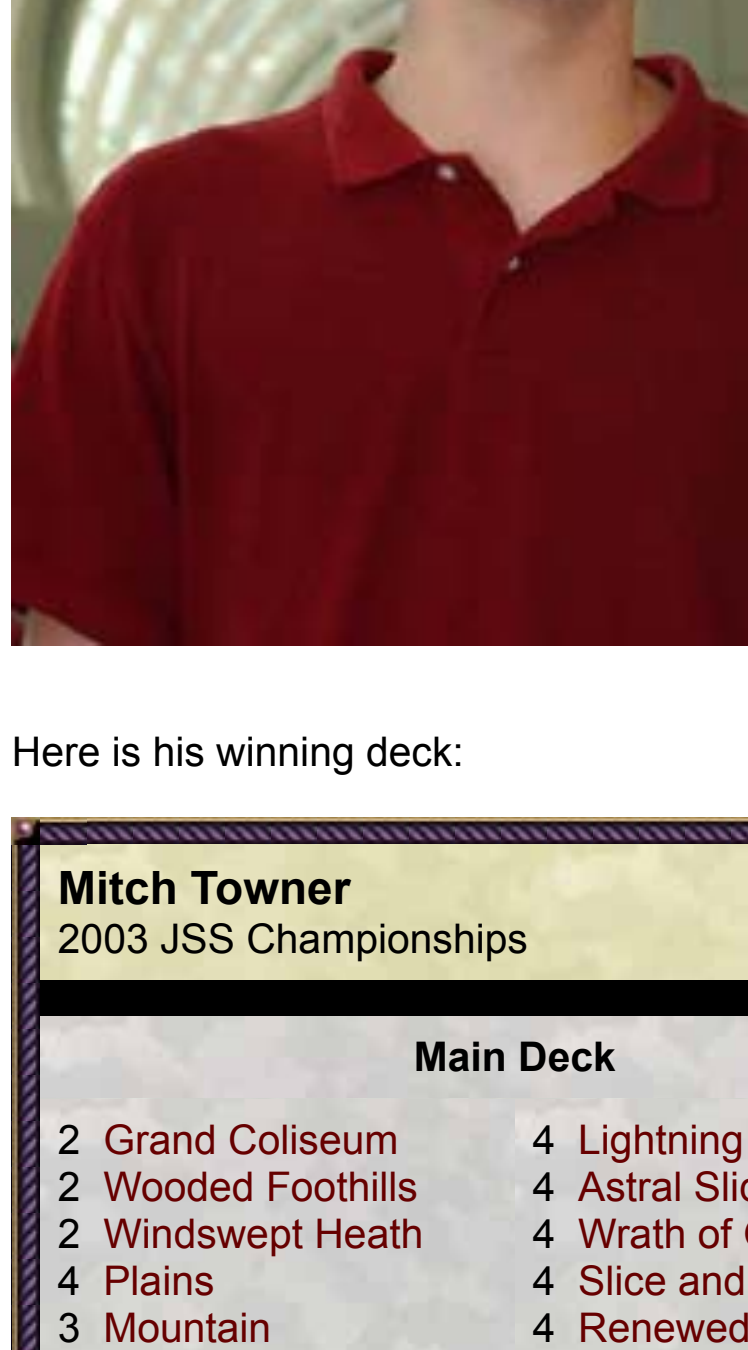
Main Deck		Sideboard
4 Karplusan Forest	2 Reckless Charge	4 Compost
4 Wooded Foothills	4 Firebolt	3 Moment's Peace
8 Mountain	4 Volcanic Hammer	2 Flaring Pain
7 Forest	4 Call of the Herd	3 Naturalize
	4 Violent Eruption	3 Static Orb
23 land		
	18 other spells	15 sideboard cards
3 Grim Lavamancer		
4 Basking Rootwalla		
4 Llanowar Elves		
4 Phantom Centaur		
4 Wild Mongrel		
19 creatures		

Coverage for the event can be found here.

JSS Championships

Ah, the Junior Super Series, my old stomping grounds.

Favorites going in were Arthur Minetz (U.S. Nationals competitor), Greg Swan (brother of former pro player Brad Swan), Alex Lecky (Canadian Nationals competitor, and JSS Top 8 last year), and Matthew Foley (motivational speaker).



The JSS, however, is a quick and brutal affair. Despite hordes of players, only nine rounds are played, which leaves no margin for error, making even a single manascrew fatal even to the best of players. A 7-0-2 record was the minimum necessary for Top 8.

The Top 8 contained a white-green beast deck, a Psychatog deck, a blue-green madness deck, two Astral Slide decks, two red-green beatdown decks, and a black-green Oversold Cemetery deck.

The finals, mirroring the U.S. Nationals Finals, pitted Mitch Towner (Slide,) versus Sam Stein (r-g.) Unlike the U.S. Nationals, however, the Slide deck, piloted by Mitch Towner (who looks old enough to have fathered a JSS'er) won. It should be noted that Mitch Towner did not lose a game over the course of 9 Swiss rounds and the Top 8. Very nicely done. Keep an eye out for this kid on the Pro Tour.

Here is his winning deck:

Mitch Towner
2003 JSS Championships

Main Deck		Sideboard
2 Grand Coliseum	4 Lightning Rift	4 Boil
2 Wooded Foothills	4 Astral Slide	4 Dwarven Blastminer
2 Windswept Heath	4 Wrath of God	2 Cartographer
4 Plains	4 Slice and Dice	2 Auramancer
3 Mountain	4 Renewed Faith	2 Ray of Revelation
2 Forest		1 Teroh's Faithful
3 Nantuko Monastery	20 other spells	
4 Tranquil Thicket		15 sideboard cards
4 Secluded Steppe		
4 Forgotten Cave		
30 land		
2 Teroh's Faithful		
4 Exalted Angel		
4 Krosan Tusker		
10 creatures		

Coverage for the event can be found here.

Of Note

US Nationals Sneak Peek: North American pro player Peter Szigeti wrote a U.S. Nationals preview that generated a lot of buzz around the water cooler. If you haven't checked it out yet, do so here.

Brazilian Boo-Boo: I made two mistakes in last week's Bad Play of the Week, Latin Letdown. First of all, it was not in fact a "Latin" letdown, as Brazil is not a Latin country (the language is Portuguese). Romao is Brazilian, not Hispanic. Secondly, Romao did have a loss before the Finals, conceding in the last round of the Swiss to a friend. Sorry to everyone that I offended. I write from the heart.

Say it Ain't So Kats! As reported in Toby Wachter's Japanese Nationals summary: "In surprising news, Mori declared even before the tournament started that this would be his last event, which means you shouldn't expect to see the former Rookie of the Year at Worlds, or any other tournaments for that matter if his mind doesn't change."

Don't go into the light, Katsuhiro! We need you! Breathe! Breathe!

A Sorry! State of Affairs: At the weekend before last's Canadian Nationals, Josh Bennett hosted a prison-rules Sorry! tournament featuring many of Canada's premier **Magic** internet writers. A self proclaimed Sorry! master, Josh offered to take all comers in a do-or-die match. In the end, he managed to defend his title, but not without a few extremely close calls. Expect a summary of the exciting game from Bennett on Starcitygames.com later this week.

Et Tu Budge? It seems recently there's been a backlash against the Cunningham Camp, with hate-articles on StarCityGames, and Misetings.com. Now, the mean-spirited jibes have reached Sideboard.com, with the opening sentence of Kai's latest article: "Jeff Cunningham wrote that I was going to post the decklists from Italy Nationals. Well, I didn't really plan to do that, but as Jeff already has enough work to clean up the "few" errors in his Week in Review, I'll just go ahead and save him some of that time."

Excuse me? Well I never!

My source for that particular bit of information was your last article! (Read 'em and weep): "I will be back this week or early next week with a brief report how I screwed up on Day 2 and thus missed Top 8 and an overview on Standard after this weekend of National competitions in Sweden, Italy and Germany."

See that, Kai? Italy. As in Italians.

I just *love* being right all the time!

Eighth Edition Rules Now Street Legal: As of July 1st, the 8th Edition rules are now legal for tournament play. The changes are all extremely minute and should have little bearing on most games. Nevertheless, it's probably good to know them. Paul Barclay sums up the tweaks here.

Lionized: Brian "The Lion" Bonnell Takes Offense at Pro Magic Clique:

The debate that ensued was heated, and has caught fire on internet discussion boards.

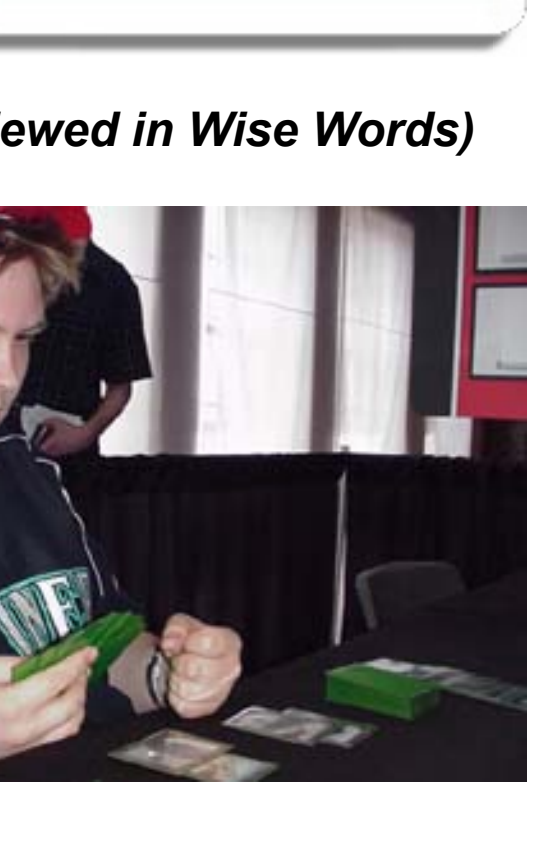
At Canadian Nationals, in the final round, "Chef" Boyd Hardie was paired down against Brian "the Lion" Bonnell. Whereas Bonnell was definitely eliminated, even with a win, it looked like Hardie could still make it; he asked for a concession, a request that Bonnell refused. Bonnell won the match 2-0, and declined yet another request for a concession from a frustrated Hardie.

After the match, Canadian pro players Gary Wise and David Rood approached Bonnell to discuss his reasons for not conceding.

The debate that ensued was heated, and has caught fire on internet discussion boards. If a player is paired up and has no chance of making Top 8, should he feel obliged to concede to his opponent on the off-chance of being given a portion of that player's prize? Is this collusion? He said, she said, what now?

Follow the debate here.

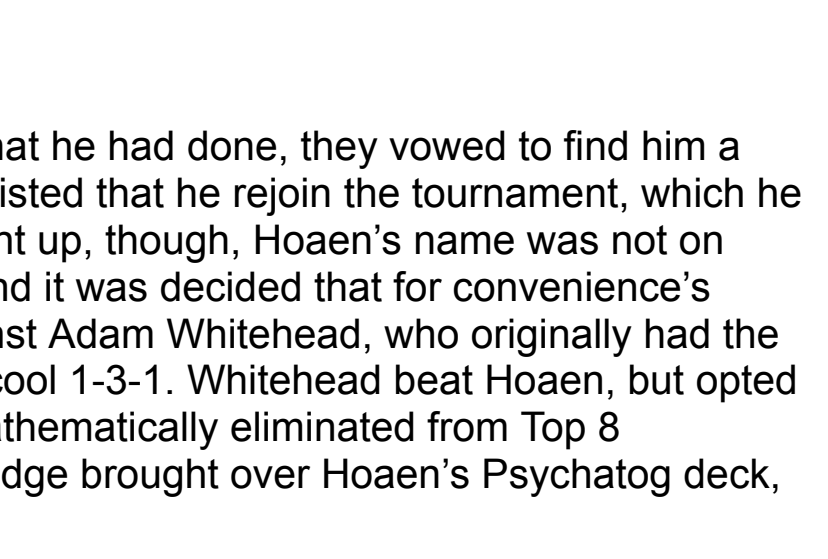
Magic Trivia



The answer to last week's question "What is Counterspell's mana cost?" is: UU.

This week's question comes courtesy of Pro Tour player Gerard Fabiano: "If there was a Constructed format using (minimum) forty card decks where the only cards legal were Phantom Whelps and islands, what configuration would be optimal? Why?"

Play of the Week: The Drop-Fake *(as previewed in Wise Words)*



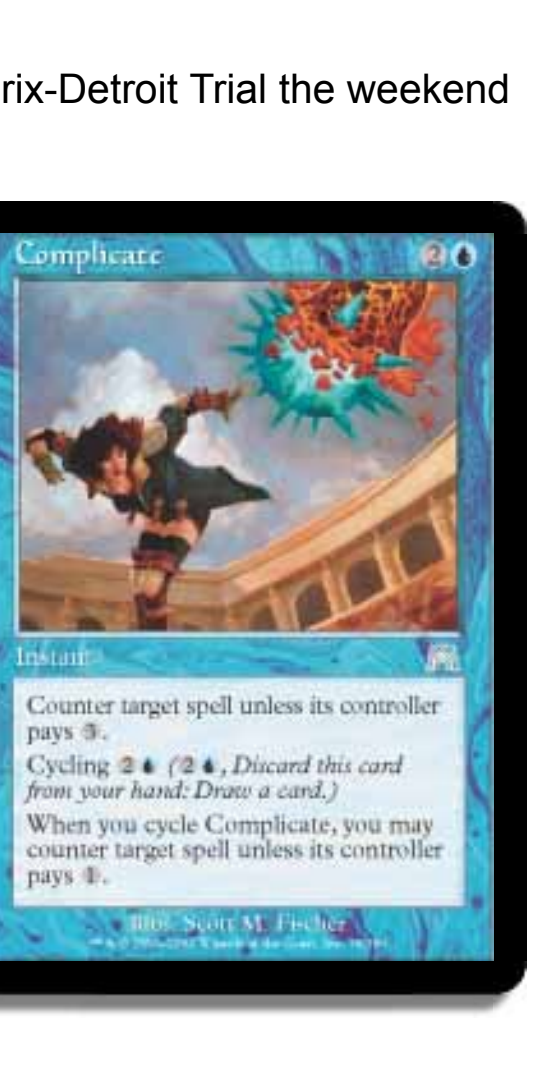
After reading the Canada Nationals coverage the weekend before last, you may have noticed Pro Tour-Yokohama Top 8 competitor Richard Hoaen playing in the Semifinals. What you may not have noticed is that he *dropped from the tournament* after the fifth round. At 3-2, Hoaen had lost his Psychatog deck and, 2-0 in his pod, was slated to play against Nick Page's monster monogreen deck, an assured auto-loss. In lieu of the situation, Hoaen decided to throw in the towel, and dropped from the tournament.

However, when he told his friends what he had done, they vowed to find him a replacement Psychatog deck and insisted that he rejoin the tournament, which he did. After the sixth round pairings went up, though, Hoaen's name was not on them. He notified the scorekeeper, and it was decided that for convenience's sake, he would be paired down against Adam Whitehead, who originally had the bye at the table and was sitting at a cool 1-3-1. Whitehead beat Hoaen, but opted to concede, since he was already mathematically eliminated from Top 8 contention. After the concession, a judge brought over Hoaen's Psychatog deck, which had been turned in.

Richard Hoaen, I award you Good Play of the Week!

Bad Play of the Week: Complicated Math

This Bad Play of the Week took place at the Grand Prix-Detroit Trial the weekend before last at Canadian Nationals.



Paul Pieczonka (Slide, splashing blue) was playing against Tony Paschos (Slide). Pieczonka had the advantage with a Rift on the table, and Paschos at a precarious 10 life. Paschos knew time was of the essence, and fist-bonked the top of his deck... he drew his card carefully, and it was what he needed! An eighth land, which allowed him to slam down Akroma, Angel of Wrath. Pieczonka was stunned. He took his 6 damage, and then, during the end-step, clearly said "I can't believe how lucky you are, now I have to dig for answers," before cycling his *Complicate*. I repeat, he cycled *Complicate*. He lost the game, and match, and finished 9th place.

Paul Pieczonka, I award you Bad Play of the Week!

Quote of the Week

"Upheaval drop Savannah Lion." - Kyle Rose, theorizing on the Worlds metagame.

Next Week

- European Championships
- A Special Section for the Ladies
- Manners and the Top 8: Jordan Berkowitz or Bore-dan Jerkowitz?

SUBSCRIBE
TO
SIDEBOARD
CLICK HERE

© 1995-2003 Wizards of the Coast, Inc., a subsidiary of Hasbro, Inc. All Rights Reserved.
Wizards is headquartered in Renton, Washington, PO Box 707, Renton, WA 98057.
PRIVACY STATEMENT